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FEATURED

Charles public schools MCAP English scores remain lower than state

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Kevin Lowndes, left, Charles public schools' chief of teaching and learning, and district administrators summarize the district's Maryland Comprehensive Assessment Program scores and district initiatives to monitor learning during the Charles school board of education meeting on Sept. 9.

Screenshot by Ilana Williams

This is the second of a two-part series looking at Charles public schools' state standardized test results.

Charles public schools saw nearly a 10% increase in English language arts for 10th grade, but remained lower than the state average on standardized tests last school year.

“The highest level cognitive demand skill that the human brain can do is writing,” Superintendent Maria Navarro told Southern Maryland News in a recent interview. “When you ask a student to tell you what they’ve learned and summarize it, they can tell you what they’re doing, but when you ask them to write down what they’re learning ... they have to use multiple skills.”

The school district on the Maryland Comprehensive Assessment Program, or MCAP, scored an average of 55.5% for English language arts for Grade 10, with the state average at 59.5%, according to data from the Maryland State Department of Education. The school district scored an average of 41.8% for English language arts for third grade, with the state average at 50%.

Students are learning how to write with writing prompts and the district has included it in core instruction, Kevin Lowndes, chief of teaching and learning at the Charles public schools system, said.

MCAP is important because it shows growth, Pascale Small, a Waldorf resident who ran in the 2024 Charles school board election and lost, said. The district is moving forward with new curriculum in math and reading to make sure children are learning the core subjects.

But the growth is not fast enough.

Small has three kids who attend William A. Diggs Elementary School.

The average of all students enrolled in third grade English language arts who scored proficient on the 2024-2025 MCAP was 36.7%.

“Growth is important to see because it means we’re heading in the right direction, [but] we are moving too slow,” Small said. “There are still too many children that are not reading at grade level, there are still too many children that are not doing math

at grade level and there are still too many children and families that are asking for real interventions and support.”

The Maryland Comprehensive Assessment Program provides information to educators, families and the public on student progress towards proficiency on the Maryland state content standards.

Students in grades 3-8 and Grade 10 take English assessments, students in grades 3-8 and those taking Algebra I take a math assessment and students in fifth and eighth grade take a science assessment. There is also an Algebra II and Geometry assessment for middle and high school students.

There are inventions being done in the classroom, but they are not consistent and the district needs more interventionists, Small said.

“We don’t have time for these children who are being left behind,” the mother said.

While there are community schools that have after school programs to help with reading and math, they should be offered at every school, Small said. Parents have recommended having a community tutoring program or after school learning program for reading and math support.

Extended learning opportunities are extended at the district’s elementary schools and Title I schools, Lowndes said. Title I schools have federal funding due to the number of students from lower-income families that can be used for extra tutoring and support.

High schools have opportunities for extended learning but they don’t necessarily bring in people to help like at the elementary schools.

High schools have a period of time built into the school day where teachers can tutor or work with groups of students in need of additional support, a statement from Charles public schools said.

“I do see the growth,” Small said. “I do see the intention. We just have to continue moving forward.”



Meghan Sasser Oct 14, 2025